

Field Report: Lantern Moth Swarm

Filed by: a shaken observer of the outer works **Condition of report:** written after withdrawal; certain passages may be imperfect

General Assessment

The **Lantern Moth Swarm** is a siege-breaker of serious threat. I use the term “swarm” reluctantly, for it suggests a multitude acting without purpose. This thing has purpose enough. It does not advance like troops, nor strike like beasts. Acting as a collective, it brings mothlike disruption against fortified positions until walls, gates, towers, and the courage behind them are made equally uncertain.

No single moth appeared dangerous. That was the first lie the swarm told us.

Appearance

At distance, the Lantern Moth Swarm resembles a dense cloud of moths. Their wings turn and vanish within one another, so that the cloud seems less made of bodies than of moving ash. Yet through the mass runs an eerie visual impression of lantern-light: pale glimmers, wavering halos, and brief golden stains upon stone.

I will not swear that any true flame burned among them. I saw no wick. I saw no oil. Still, the light was present. It gathered along the battlements and trembled in the arrow slits. Men reached toward it, believing it near enough to grasp. Those men were not seen clearly afterward.

Observed Behavior

The swarm was restless from its first appearance. It did not settle. It pressed, recoiled, divided, and returned, always finding another opening through which to worry the defenders. Shutters were closed; it found the cracks. Helmets were tightened; it filled the breathing space. Cloaks were drawn over faces; the cloth fluttered as though something beneath it wished to be let out.

Its assault was overwhelming without being loud. The air became a constant dry whisper. Sight failed in patches. Orders crossed one another, then ceased altogether. Some defenders abandoned their posts before the wall was touched. Others struck at empty light until their weapons broke against stone.

I record this with shame: escape did not appear to be a matter of speed. The Lantern Moth Swarm made every direction seem occupied. Those who fled into open ground found the cloud before them. Those who remained behind the fortification found it within.

Conclusion

Do not mistake the Lantern Moth Swarm for vermin, smoke, or a mere nuisance of the night. It is a dense cloud with the force of a breach. It is restless, overwhelming, and difficult to escape. Fortifications may resist iron, fire, and ordinary assault. Against this thing, a wall becomes only a place for the lantern-light to gather.

If the cloud is sighted, conceal the lamps and prepare to abandon any position that cannot be sealed completely. I offer no stronger counsel because I possess none.